



Preventing Frostbite



For Everyone

[AUG. 25, 2026](#)

KEY POINTS

- Frostbite is a dangerous condition that can happen when a person is exposed to extremely cold temperatures.
- Stay safe this winter by learning more about frostbite, including who is most at risk, signs and symptoms, and what to do if someone develops frostbite.

Overview



If you notice redness or pain in any skin area, get out of the cold or protect any exposed skin—frostbite may be beginning.

What is frostbite?

Frostbite is a type of injury caused by freezing. It leads to a loss of feeling and color in the areas it affects, usually extremities such as the nose, ears, cheeks, chin, fingers, and toes. Frostbite can permanently damage the body, and severe cases can lead to amputation (removing the affected body part).

Risk factors

You may have a greater chance of developing frostbite if you:

- Have poor blood circulation

- Are not properly dressed for extremely cold temperatures

What to look out for

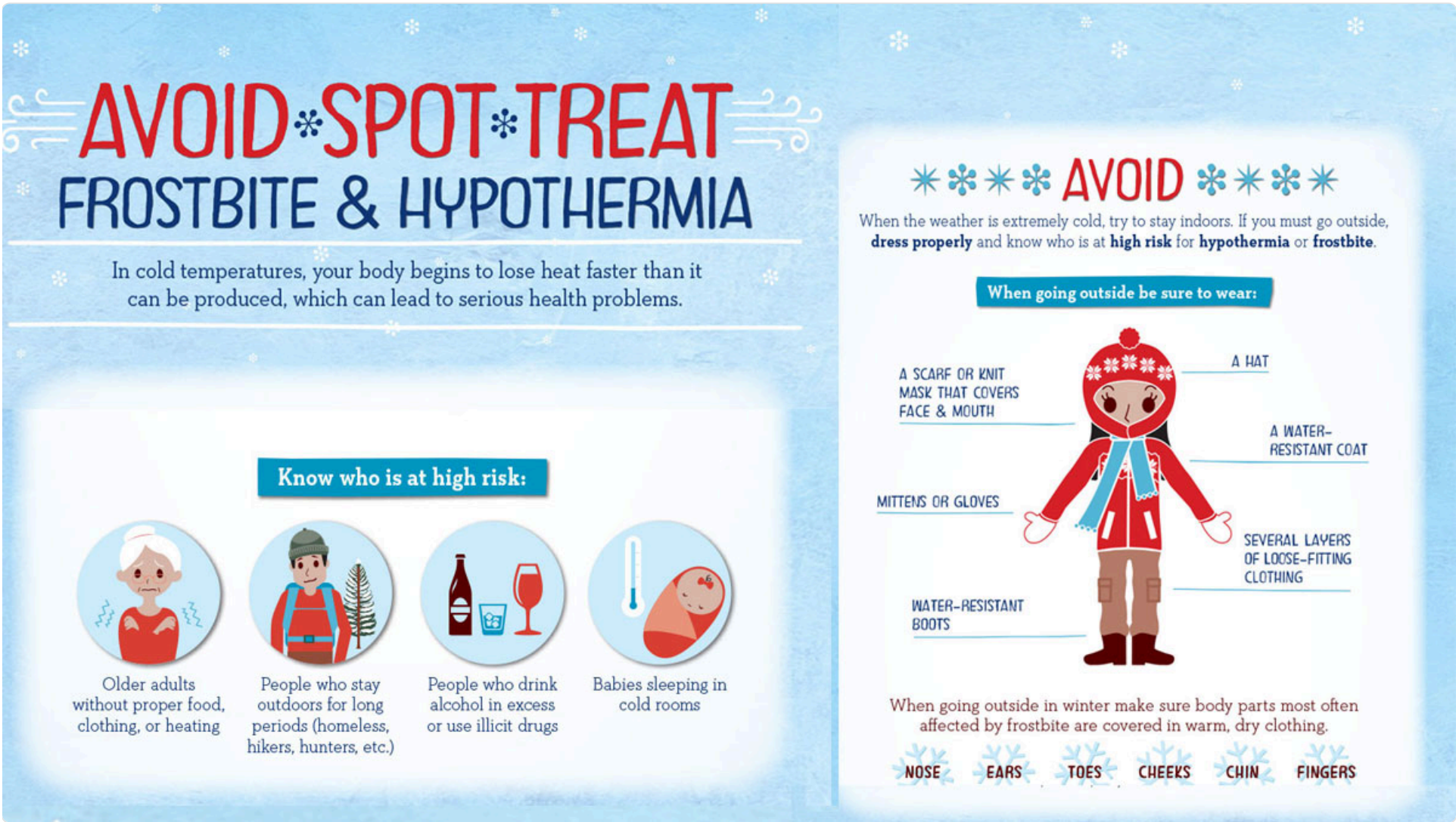
If you notice redness or pain in any skin area, get out of the cold or protect any exposed skin—frostbite may be beginning.

Any of the following signs may point to frostbite:

- A white or grayish-yellow skin area
- Skin that feels unusually firm or waxy
- Numbness

A person who has frostbite may not know they have it until someone else points it out because the frozen parts of their body are numb.

Don't wait— take action



In cold temperatures, your body can begin to lose heat faster than it can be produced, which can lead to serious health problems.

Avoid, spot, treat frostbite & hypothermia.

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Avoid

When the weather is extremely cold, try to stay indoors. If you must go outside, dress properly and know who is at high risk for hypothermia or frostbite. When going outside be sure to wear: a scarf or knit mask that covers face and mouth; a hat; mittens of gloves; a water-resistant coat; water-resistant boots; and several layers of loose-fitting clothing.

When going outside in winter make sure body parts most often affected by frostbite are covered in warm, dry clothing: nose, ears, toes, cheeks, chin, and fingers.

Know who is at high risk: older adults without proper food, clothing, or heating; people who stay outdoors for long periods (homeless, hikers, hunters, etc.); people who drink alcohol in excess or use illicit drugs; and babies sleeping in cold rooms.

Spot

Frostbite

A victim is often unaware of frostbite because frozen tissue is numb.

Signs & Symptoms: Redness or pain in any skin area may be the first sign of frostbite. Other signs include: a white or grayish-yellow skin area; skin that feels unusually firm or waxy; and numbness

Hypothermia

Hypothermia often occurs at very cold temperatures, but can occur at cool temperatures (above 40 degrees Fahrenheit), if a person is wet (from rain, sweat, or cold water) and becomes chilled.

Signs & Symptoms

Adults: shivering, exhaustion, confusion, fumbling hands, memory loss, slurred speech, drowsiness.

Infants: bright red, cold skin, and very low energy.

If a person's temperature is below 95 degrees get medical attention immediately.

Treat

If a person is experiencing hypothermia or frostbite...

- 1) Seek medical attention as soon as possible.
- 2) Get them into a warm room or shelter.
- 3) Remove any wet clothing.
- 4) Warm them under dry layers of blankets and clothing.
- 5) Place areas affected by frostbite in warm-to-touch water.

Frostbite Caution

Since skin may be numb, victims of frostbite can harm themselves further. Use caution when treating frostbite and:

- 1) Unless necessary, do not walk on feet or toes with frostbite.
- 2) Do not use a fireplace, heat lamp, radiator, or stove for warming.
- 3) Do not use a heating pad or electric blanket for warming.
- 4) Do not rub or massage areas with frostbite.

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If you notice signs of frostbite on yourself or someone else, seek medical care. Check to see if the person is also showing signs of hypothermia. Hypothermia is a more serious condition and requires emergency medical care.

If (1) a person shows signs of frostbite, but no signs of hypothermia and (2) immediate medical care is not available, do the following:

- Get the person into a warm room as soon as possible.
- Unless absolutely necessary, do not walk on feet or toes that show signs of frostbite—this increases the damage.
- Do not rub the frostbitten area with snow or massage it at all. This can cause more damage.
- Put the areas affected by frostbite in warm—not hot—water (the temperature should be comfortable to the touch for unaffected parts of the body).
- If warm water is not available, warm the affected area using body heat. For example, you can use the heat of an armpit to warm frostbitten fingers.
- Do not use a heating pad, heat lamp, or the heat of a stove, fireplace, or radiator for warming. Affected areas are numb and can easily burn.

Don't substitute these steps for proper medical care. Frostbite should be checked by a health care provider. And remember, hypothermia is a medical emergency and immediate medical care is necessary.

Be prepared.

Taking a first aid or emergency resuscitation (CPR) course is a good way to prepare for health problems related to cold weather. Knowing what to do is an important part of protecting your health and the health of others.

Being prepared is your best defense against having to deal with extremely cold weather. By preparing your home and car ahead of winter storms or other winter emergencies, and by taking safety precautions during extremely cold weather, you can reduce your risk of developing health problems related to cold weather.

Resources

- [Natural Disasters and Severe Weather](#)
- [Winter Weather | Ready.gov](#) 
- [Winter Storm Preparedness & Blizzard Safety | Red Cross](#) 
- [Winter \(weather.gov\)](#) 

SOURCES AND PAGE INFO

CONTENT SOURCE

[National Center for Environmental Health](#)

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